
Paper 2, Option 2F.1: India, c1914–48: the road to independence

Overview

This option comprises a study in depth of the transition of the Indian sub-continent from a colony to independence. The gaining of Indian independence influenced both the nature of civil rights campaigning and the search for national self-determination throughout the world.

Students will gain an in-depth understanding of the changing relationship between Britain and India from the outbreak of the First World War to the achievement of independence for the Indian sub-continent, and of the reasons for this, with particular reference to Indian nationalism.

Key topics	Content
1 The First World War and its impact on British India, 1914–20	• India in 1914: political geography; the British Raj; Indian society and religion; importance of India to Britain; British and Indian attitudes towards each other; Indian nationalism. • India and the First World War: response to the outbreak of war; Indian military and economic contribution; economic impact in India and consequences for British rule. • Effects of war on British rule: the impact on the Raj; the Montagu Declaration; the Rowlatt Acts. The Amritsar massacre and political aftermath; the Montagu-Chelmsford Report and the Government of India Act; significance of 1919 for British rule. • The growth of nationalism: impact of war; the Indian National Congress and emergence of Gandhi; the Lucknow Pact and role of Jinnah; Home Rule Leagues; response to British legislation and the significance of Amritsar, 1919–20.
2 Changing political relationships, 1920–30	• Gandhi and civil disobedience, 1920–22: Gandhi's aims and beliefs; his becoming leader of Congress 1920; the non-cooperation campaign; significance of his imprisonment. • Congress reorganised, 1922–30: membership and organisation; political participation and 'back to basics'; the 'young hooligans'; the Nehru Report; the Lahore Congress and <i>purna swaraj</i>; the salt <i>satyagraha</i> and consequences of civil disobedience. • The Muslim League: the <i>Khilafat</i> movement; re-emergence of Muslim values; the concept of separateness; breakdown of relations with Congress; Jinnah's beliefs and aims; the significance of failed attempts to reunite with Congress.

Key topics	Content
3 Consultation and confrontation, 1930–42	• Failure of the Round Table Conferences, 1930–32: the First, Second and Third Conferences; reasons for failure, including the role of Congress, the situation in Britain and divisions over separate elections. • Political developments, 1932–35: Indian reaction to the failure of consultation; the Communal Award and Gandhi's response; the Yeravda Pact; support and opposition in Britain for constitutional change. • Government of India Act and its impact, 1935–39: partial implementation; nationalist response. Outcome of the 1937 elections; rejuvenation of the Muslim League; divisions within Congress; attitudes towards the British Raj. • Reaction to outbreak of the Second World War: Congress and Muslim League responses to the declaration of war; the Lahore Resolution; nationalist reaction to the August Offer; Bose and the Axis Powers.
4 The road to independence, 1942–48	• Impact of the Second World War on Indian politics: threat of invasion; the Cripps Mission; the 'Quit India Campaign' and its repercussions; Wavell's appointment as Viceroy; the Bengal Famine; the failure of the Simla Conference 1945. • The changing relationship between Britain and India, 1942–45: impact of war on British rule and Indian nationalism; the influence of the USA; the Labour government's Indian policy. • Attempts at political settlement, 1945–46, including the impact of Indian elections; failure of the Cabinet Mission; Direct Action; interim government under Nehru. • Withdrawal, partition and independence, 1947–48: Mountbatten and the decision to withdraw; reasons for partition and the nationalist response; the partition plan; the Boundary Commission; independence for India and Pakistan. British withdrawal and communal violence.